

THE BOSS
PM Modi addresses the crowds in Australia

start of his second term. Its aim was to ensure that every rural household was supplied with 55 litres of water per person a day (per WHO norms) through functional household taps. It was a tall order, as barely 32 million or 16 per cent of the 194 million rural households had tap water supply in 2019. Modi set aside Rs 3.6 lakh crore over five years for the scheme.

Lal, who was its first mission director, used technology, including data analytics, AI and IoT, to monitor its implementation down to each household, building a transparent database and dashboard to track progress. In the past four years, 89 million rural households have been provided with tap water—as on May 31, 2023, some 121 million households or 62 per cent stand covered. It is a stupendous achievement that matches the funding and building of 110 million toilets in individual houses as part of the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan, sharply reducing the widespread practice of open defecation and was of immense help especially for women in rural areas.

HIGH ON DIGITISATION

If Rajiv Gandhi brought computers to India during his tenure as prime minister in the 1980s, Modi has taken digitisation to an altogether different and higher level. He upgraded the vast physical digital infrastructure his predecessors Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Dr Manmohan Singh had built in their tenures and converted it into a massive force multiplier for governance. Amitabh Kant, the flamboyant and articulate former CEO of NITI Aayog and currently India's sherpa for the upcoming G20 summit in Delhi, says the digital revolution ushered in by Modi has proved to be a game-changer in the country's development. Modi oversaw the universalisation of digital identities and pushed for the opening of a phenomenal 400 million Jan Dhan bank accounts for India's unbanked poor during his first term. From just 17 per cent women who had a bank account when the scheme started, the figure is well over 80 per cent today, a sign of true empowerment. By linking Jan Dhan accounts then with Aadhaar cards as identity proofs and providing mobile connectivity through what Modi christened the JAM trinity, he was able to facilitate speedy digital transfer of money for welfare programmes under the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) scheme.

It put an immediate end to the enormous leakage in rural funds and curbed corruption. As Rajiv Gandhi had famously said, for every Re 1 the government set aside for welfare schemes meant for the poor, only 15 paise reached the beneficiary. DBT changed that significantly. "When the Digital India movement started in 2016, we were 123rd in the world in terms of data consumption," says